

Q1. Is conformity always desirable?

Key Terms:

Conformity: correspondence or agreement in form, nature or character (the act of acting in accord with the prevailing standards, attitudes and practices).

Conformity involves changing your behaviours in order to "fit in" or "go along" with the people around you. This change in belief is in response to real (involving the physical presence of others) or imagined (involving the pressure of social norms / expectations) group pressure.

Always: Absolute proposition. The key term 'always' invites the candidate to give a qualified response, that is, to agree that while it is good/desirable for some reasons, it may not always be good.

Desirable: worth having or wanting

Recommended Stand: Yes, it is good and desirable to conform **if the motivation and the likely consequences of conformity bring about positive changes and improvements to the individual and/or society.** However, this may not always be the case.

Approach:

- A. Generally, conformity is desirable when it brings about positive impacts and improvements to the individual and/or society.
- B. However, this may not always be the case as conformist behaviour may not always bring about desirable outcomes

Suggested Approach:

Part A. Generally, conformity is desirable when brings about positive impacts and improvements to the individual and/or society.

1. **Conformity is desirable for people who conform so that they do not run the risk of being ostracized by their peers. People who act and do as others do tend to be pretty well accepted.**

Very often, most people just follow and comply because they want to be liked and accepted or approved by others. As such, these conformists dread the prospect of being socially rejected due to their failure to conform to some popular pattern.

Example: Often, youth want to establish trust relationships with their peers and so they conform to avoid standing out for fear of being judged or exiled. When youth select friends and join cliques, they often dress and act like friends or members of the clique in order to satisfy the need for a sense of belonging. For instance, working-class adolescents in the multicultural parts of London conform to similar patterns of language use by using a variety of English known as Multicultural London English to foster rapport and belonging.

2. **Conformity is usually desirable as it provides a safe track to success. Following tried and tested ways of doing things may decrease the possibility of failure and bring about assured results.**

Most people often choose to conform rather than pursue personal desires because it is often easier to follow the path others have made already, rather than creating a new one. Most of us actually prefer to follow the pack. By being conformist, we copy the things that are popular in the world and those things are often good and useful and that is why many others are doing it, so it cannot be wrong.

Example: From traditional recipes to conventional education and career choices, conformity provides better chances of weeding out ambiguity/uncertainties for a safer route to success. In China, students and parents follow the tried and tested formula to gain entrance to elite colleges like Peking or Tsinghua University, and end up joining banking (which makes the most money and because everyone is doing it) or the state sector (which guarantees security and *guanxi*, or personal contacts, and can protect your family from an unpredictable system) because these educational/career choices offer the best guarantee for social advancement.

3. **Society can function smoothly when people conform to societal norms. People see that there is a greater good which can be achieved when everyone conforms to societal standards/norms in one form or another.**

Norms provide order and structure in society and these norms are often created by rules/guidelines. Human beings need norms to guide and direct their behavior, to provide order and predictability in social relationships and to make sense of and understand each other's actions. This helps to keep in check the tendency to do the wrong things. Thus, conformity bolsters society's foundations and holds society together.

A case in point:

Covid-19 pandemic.

In the recent Covid pandemic days, most societies **cannot afford** to face disruptions caused by nonconformist behaviours such as protests against the wearing of masks and lockdowns. Adherents of QAnon, ultra-evangelicals and anti-vaxxers, to right-wing populists or even the sovereign citizens aka "sovcits", have been making headlines around the world for refusing to comply with measures to deal with the pandemic. In our own backyard, one nonconformist featured the "badge lady", Phoon Chiu Yoke, notorious for refusing to wear a mask and self-righteously confronting a safe distancing ambassador when told to do so. She stood in stark contrast to the vast majority in Singapore who have masked up diligently, despite the personal discomfort in heat and humidity. Such nonconformist action can be seen as an extreme form of polarisation in society amid a social condition, such as the pandemic. While most people are willing to put up with the inconveniences of complying with safe distancing measures, there are those who take it to extremes and decide they live in an alternative reality where the rules do not apply to them. **In not complying with societal rules, they become public health menace** with their medical conspiracy theories leading to mistrust towards institutions.

B However, this may not always be the case as conformist behaviour may not always bring about desirable outcomes.

1. **Conformist culture can stifle innovation and breeds stagnation. People conform because they do not like change and this in turn may inhibit creativity.**

Creating and dreaming-up new approaches and challenging the status-quo are all necessary for innovation and creative problem-solving. However, conformists tend to be reluctant to challenge or invent, instead preferring to tread the well-trodden path. **Most** people stick to their patterns of behaviour because they see no reason to disrupt things in the near term.

A case in point: Many Singaporeans conforming to the idea that an education in science yields more success in career and is preferred over the arts, hence leading to a situation where there is a lack of creativity in the field of arts.

In a world dominated by digital transformation, companies in over-saturated markets have begun to differentiate themselves through non-conformity. Many outstanding, different and remarkable inventions that have transformed how we live and work were started by people who believed change was inevitable.

Example

- Uber has helped the common New Yorker to have instant access to a driver. Because Uber was unwilling to conform and accept transportation as it existed in the early 2000s, they reinvented transportation, thus disrupting the entire marketplace. The result: in 2015, Uber, an “American worldwide online transportation network company”, was named the most disruptive company and most highly valued start up.
- A nonconformist, Steve Jobs asserted his rebellious and counterculture streak in the way he pushed for the success of Apple products. He also dreamed of producing magical tools for digital photography and ways to make television simple and personal. His rules for success helped him build a company that not only create these and other disruptive products but will stand at the intersection of creativity and technology, all of which that has made Apple a leading corporate in the field of telecommunications.

2. Conformity is certainly not desirable if it forces a person to be someone whom they are not, leading to them to compromise their individuality and values

Too much conformity can lead to a loss of identity and mindless actions in order to maintain acceptance within a certain group. It destroys the uniqueness and confidence of an individual if one is conditioned into believing that looking and acting a certain way, one that fits social norms, is the only acceptable way to carry themselves.

When an individual conforms out of laziness or convenience instead of thinking through his choice and decision, he is simply surrendering his standing as an individual because he does not see past the simplicity and comfort of what he feels and knows.

In some cases of conformity, a person's desire to fit in with a social group can even result in one compromising his values/principles and interfere with the ability to make moral or safe decisions. One example is when a person drinks and drives because friends do it, or because friends assure that person he or she can safely do so.

3. Conformity is not desirable when it ends up perpetuating a system or situation that is corrupt or oppressive.

People tend to conform because they do not think they are capable of changing things or they do not have the courage to go against the system. In this respect, conformity can inhibit people from speaking out on injustices or flaws in the system that could actually improve a situation or a decision.

E.g.: Covid-19:

Conformity is a key trait of the Communist Party of China's (CPC) style of governance. Faithfulness to the party's core leadership is characterized by staunch loyalty to the CPC Central Committee, its General Secretary Xi Jinping, party principles and acting in accordance with party policies.

While such conformity has ensured that the Chinese government has remained united on the same goal of economic development and enabled China's rapid rise to become an economic superpower, it has also stifled dissent necessary for progress and reform.

It is believed by many that the spread of Covid-19 can be attributed to the mishandling of the situation by the leaders of the province where the disease originated from. Instead of being transparent about the worsening situation, the local Public Security Bureau covered the news and the whistleblower doctor (Dr Li Wenliang who has since died from the disease) as well as the media were state silenced when Li raised the alarm about the potential threat of the virus.

This is an example of conformist behaviour or policy gone wrong when public officials/media conform to certain principles/beliefs (to ensure the reputation of the ruling government in this case) in an unthinking manner because they fear reprisal as a result of challenging the status quo/higher ups. Conformity thus impairs civil society's ability to detect and sound the alarm on problems